

FACTIFY –SPOT THE FAKE, PLAY THE TRUTH

An Interactive Media Literacy Initiative Against Misinformation in Pakistan



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CHAPTER 1: INTRODUCTION

Fake news has become one of the most pressing challenges in Pakistan's media environment today. From WhatsApp forwards and viral TikTok videos to manipulated political posts on Facebook, misinformation spreads faster than most people can verify it. This creates confusion, fuels divisions, influences public opinion unfairly, and often causes serious harm in real life situations such as elections, public health campaigns, or even communal relations.

The challenge of misinformation is not unique to Pakistan it is a global phenomenon. Around the world, fake news has been identified as a major threat to democracy, social cohesion, and even global security. During crises such as the COVID-19 pandemic, misinformation about vaccines and treatments put lives at risk. Similarly, in the political arena, the spread of false narratives has swayed elections, disrupted trust in media, and weakened public confidence in institutions. These realities highlight the urgency of developing creative, youth-centered solutions to build resilience against misinformation.

As Mass Communication students, the project recognized the need to engage peers through a modern and interactive approach. Instead of creating another traditional awareness campaign which young audiences might ignore we developed Factify: an interactive mobile app designed as a game. In Factify, players step into the role of a journalist or fact-checker. They are shown real Pakistani headlines, memes, and social media posts, and their job is to decide whether the news is real or fake. Each choice provides instant feedback with a short explanation about why it is true or false, teaching players practical and lifelong skills for spotting misinformation.

By gamifying the process, Factify makes media literacy engaging and enjoyable.

Through this project, it will aim to:

- Raise awareness about the growing problem of misinformation in Pakistan.
- Equip young people with critical thinking and fact-checking skills when consuming news and digital content.

- Create a digital tool that integrates Mass Communication with technology to make education both fun and effective.
- Demonstrate how digital platforms can be leveraged to solve pressing social issues beyond entertainment.

SIGNIFICANCE:

Despite its limitations, Factify holds significant value in addressing a critical societal challenge. It introduces an innovative way of teaching media literacy through gamification—an approach that appeals strongly to youth audiences. By encouraging players to think critically, question sources, and verify information, Factify equips them with skills that are essential in the digital age.

The project demonstrates the power of combining Mass Communication with technology to create practical solutions. It also highlights the role of youth-led initiatives in combating misinformation and contributing positively to society. Ultimately, Factify helps lay the foundation for a more informed, critical, and resilient generation.

ALIGNMENT WITH SDGS:

The United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) provide a comprehensive global framework aimed at addressing social, economic, and environmental challenges by the year 2030. They emphasize collaboration across governments, institutions, and civil society to ensure a better and more equitable future for all. As a youth-led initiative, Factify contributes meaningfully to this global agenda by leveraging technology and media literacy as tools for social impact.

First, SDG 4: Quality Education is directly supported through Factify. Education today extends beyond classrooms; it includes equipping young people with digital literacy, critical thinking, and the ability to navigate complex information landscapes. Factify transforms the conventional idea of media literacy into an engaging, gamified format that appeals to youth.

By challenging players to identify fake news, providing feedback, and explaining why certain information is false, Factify acts as an educational tool. It not only raises awareness about misinformation but also builds a culture of inquiry and evidence-based decisionmaking. This aligns with SDG 4's emphasis on inclusive, equitable, and lifelong learning opportunities.

Second, SDG 9: Industry, Innovation, and Infrastructure is advanced through Factify's integration of Mass Communication and modern technology. The project demonstrates how innovation can be applied beyond profit-making ventures to address pressing social issues. By designing a mobile application prototype that combines fact-checking with gamification, the team showcases how digital infrastructure can support education and public awareness. Moreover, Factify encourages a mindset of innovation among students, inspiring them to think about how digital tools can be adapted for solving societal challenges. This directly contributes to the development of a knowledge-driven, innovative culture in Pakistan.

Third, SDG 16: Peace, Justice, and Strong Institutions is reinforced by Factify's mission to counter misinformation. Fake news undermines public trust in democratic institutions, polarizes societies, and in some cases even incites violence. By teaching individuals to critically evaluate information, Factify strengthens civic responsibility and promotes transparency. An informed citizenry is better able to hold leaders accountable, resist manipulation, and contribute to building stronger and more resilient institutions. In this way, Factify does not only serve as an educational initiative but also as a democratic safeguard against the harmful consequences of misinformation. In summary, Factify's alignment with SDG 4, SDG 9, and SDG 16 highlights its significance beyond the classroom. It becomes part of a global movement to foster education, innovation, and good governance through responsible use of technology and creative youth engagement.

ROADMAP OF THE PROJECT:

1. To transform Factify from an idea into a functioning and impactful initiative, it will have outlined a clear and structured roadmap. This ensures that every stage of the project from research to launch is systematic, practical, and measurable.

2. **Research and Content Collection** Gather real examples of fake news circulating on social media platforms such as Facebook, WhatsApp, and TikTok. Alongside these, compile fact-checks from authentic and reliable sources to use in explanations within the app.
3. **Content Creation** – Develop simple, easy-to-read explanations that provide immediate feedback for players. In addition, design sample posters and digital teasers that can be used to generate curiosity and spread awareness about the app among target audiences.
4. **Prototype Development** – Build a prototype of the mobile application using userfriendly development tools. This version will be bilingual (Urdu and English), visually engaging, and accessible, ensuring inclusivity for different segments of youth.
5. **Testing and Feedback** – Conduct trials with a selected group of students and young professionals to test the app. Collect data on usability, clarity, engagement, and learning outcomes to refine the product.
6. **Campaign Launch** – Run a mini-campaign under the tagline 'Factify – Seek the Truth.' Posters, short videos, and social media teasers will be used to promote the app and encourage young people to engage with it.
7. **Final Documentation and Presentation** – Compile research findings, app prototype details, campaign materials, user feedback, and lessons learned into a comprehensive final report and presentation.

DELIMITATIONS:

The scope of this project is intentionally restricted to make it more focused and manageable:

- **Geographical Focus** – The project primarily targets misinformation in Pakistan's digital space.
- **Target Audience** – The app is designed mainly for young people, particularly students and early professionals.
- **Prototype Model** – Factify will be developed as a prototype rather than a full-scale commercial application.

- Content Selection – Only a limited range of fake news examples will be included, focusing on the most common and impactful cases.
- Campaign Scale – The awareness campaign will be small, primarily digital, and localized rather than national.

CHAPTER 2: LITERATURE REVIEW

The rapid expansion of digital communication technologies has transformed how people consume, share, and interpret news. However, this same revolution has also enabled the unprecedented spread of misinformation commonly referred to as “fake news.” Scholars define fake news as fabricated information that mimics news media content in form but not in organizational process or intent (Lazer et al., 2018). The issue has become particularly acute in developing countries such as Pakistan, where social media platforms often serve as the primary source of information for large segments of the population (Khan & Zubair, 2021). As internet access grows, so does the risk of exposure to unverified or deliberately misleading content, creating significant challenges for both media consumers and democratic institutions.

Fake News and Its Societal Impact

Globally, misinformation has been identified as one of the top threats to modern society (World Economic Forum, 2019). During the COVID-19 pandemic, for instance, the World Health

Organization (WHO) described the parallel “infodemic” as a crisis of overwhelming false information that undermined public health responses (WHO, 2020). In Pakistan, studies have found that social media platforms such as Facebook, WhatsApp, and TikTok play a central role in spreading unverified news, particularly during political campaigns and national emergencies (Haider & Ali, 2022). The absence of effective fact-checking mechanisms, low digital literacy, and the emotional appeal of sensational stories make Pakistani audiences especially vulnerable (Javed & Raza, 2023).

The social consequences of misinformation are severe—it fosters polarization, erodes trust in journalism, and manipulates public opinion (Pennycook & Rand, 2021). In the political context, false narratives can distort electoral processes, while in health and social domains, they can encourage dangerous behaviors. As Wardle and Derakhshan (2017) note, misinformation and

disinformation weaken civic engagement and democratic participation by exploiting human psychology and information ecosystems.

Media Literacy as a Solution

Researchers consistently highlight media literacy as one of the most effective tools to combat misinformation. Media literacy refers to the ability to critically analyze, evaluate, and create media content (Potter, 2019). When individuals understand how media messages are produced and circulated, they become less susceptible to manipulation. The European Commission (2018) emphasizes that digital literacy and fact-checking education must be integrated into youth learning to develop informed citizens.

In the South Asian context, however, media literacy initiatives remain limited and often confined to academic or journalistic circles (Khan & Awan, 2022). Pakistani youth, despite being among the highest consumers of social media content, often lack awareness of verification tools and critical evaluation strategies. This gap calls for innovative and interactive educational approaches that can appeal to young audiences and help them learn practical fact-checking skills in engaging ways.

Gamification in Education

One such promising approach is gamification—the use of game-based elements such as challenges, scoring, and rewards in non-gaming contexts to enhance motivation and learning (Deterding et al., 2011). Gamified learning transforms passive information consumption into active participation, making complex subjects more accessible and memorable. Studies show that educational games improve engagement, information retention, and critical thinking skills (Hamari et al., 2016).

In the field of media literacy, projects like “Bad News” (Roozenbeek & van der Linden, 2019) and “Go Viral!” (Basol et al., 2020) have demonstrated how gamification can effectively inoculate

users against misinformation. These games allow players to experience the tactics of fake news creation, helping them recognize manipulative techniques in real life. Evidence from such interventions shows measurable improvements in participants' ability to identify false information (van der Linden et al., 2020).

Digital Media and Youth Engagement in Pakistan

For Pakistan, leveraging gamified learning for media literacy is both timely and necessary. The country's youth population—comprising over 60% of its demographic—is digitally active and highly engaged on platforms such as TikTok, Instagram, and WhatsApp (UNDP, 2021). However, this engagement often occurs without adequate critical awareness. Research indicates that young users in Pakistan tend to trust content shared by peers rather than verifying its source (Aslam & Shabbir, 2023). This behavioral tendency underscores the importance of designing educational interventions that align with youth culture and digital habits.

The Factify project positions itself precisely at this intersection of media literacy, technology, and youth engagement. By integrating real-life fake news examples from the Pakistani context into an interactive game, Factify addresses the need for localized, relatable learning. Similar to the approaches used by Roozenbeek and van der Linden (2019), Factify uses immediate feedback to reinforce correct responses and explain why certain information is misleading. This not only strengthens users' analytical skills but also promotes a sense of agency and responsibility toward verifying information before sharing it.

Theoretical Underpinning and Relevance

The Factify initiative can be understood through the lens of inoculation theory, which suggests that exposing individuals to weakened forms of misinformation builds resistance against future exposure (McGuire, 1964). By simulating the process of identifying fake news, Factify “vaccinates” users cognitively, enabling them to critically evaluate real-world content. Moreover, its interactive design aligns with constructivist learning theory, which posits that learners build

knowledge more effectively through experience and reflection rather than passive instruction (Piaget, 1970). Factify also aligns with global policy frameworks such as the UN Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), particularly SDG 4 (Quality Education) and SDG 16 (Peace, Justice, and Strong Institutions). By fostering digital literacy, transparency, and responsible citizenship, projects like Factify contribute directly to societal resilience in the information age.

CHAPTER 3: METHODOLOGY

1. TARGET AUDIENCE:

The primary target audience for the Factify project includes:

- Youth aged 15–30
- University and college students who actively use social media
- Early-career professionals who rely on digital platforms for information
- Frequent social media users

This demographic is selected because it is the most digitally active segment in Pakistan and is highly exposed to misinformation, while also being receptive to interactive and visual learning tools.

2. LOCATION:

The project focuses on:

- Islamabad
- Lahore
- Karachi
- Rawalpindi

These urban and semi-urban areas have high internet penetration, greater smartphone access, and a strong youth presence, making them suitable for implementing and testing the Factify project.

3. PLATFORMS:

Primary Platform

- Instagram (Reels, Stories, Posts, and Interactive Polls)

The project will run exclusively on Instagram to ensure focused content delivery, higher engagement, and easier campaign management. Instagram's visual and interactive features make it an effective platform for spreading media literacy awareness among youth.

4. TOOLS REQUIRED:

Design & Content Creation

- Canva – Visual posts, reels covers, and campaign creatives
- CapCut / Adobe Premiere Rush – Video editing for reels

Research & Coordination

- Online fact-checking resources – Content verification
- WhatsApp / Email – Team communication and coordination

Media & Promotion

- Instagram Insights – Performance and engagement tracking

5. COLOR SCHEME:

Primary Colors

- Blue – Represents trust, credibility, and clarity
- White – Clean and minimal background

Secondary Colors

- Dark Gray – Used for text readability and contrast
- Light Gray – Soft backgrounds and supporting UI elements

Accent Color

- Golden Yellow – Used for highlights, alerts, and attention-grabbing elements

6. **BUDGETING:**

The project will follow a minimal and student-friendly budget, focusing only on essential expenses. Estimated Monthly Budget (PKR):

- Graphic Designing & Content Tools: PKR 3,000
- Instagram Promotion (Minimal Ads/Boosting): PKR 5,000
- Internet/Data Costs: PKR 2,000
- Miscellaneous (Printing, small tools, storage): PKR 2,000

Total Estimated Budget: PKR 12,000 per month This budget supports content creation, basic promotion, internet usage, and minor operational needs while remaining cost-effective and realistic.

7. **SWOT ANALYSIS:**

Strengths:

- Creative and youth-oriented media literacy initiative
- Instagram-focused strategy ensures high engagement
- Low-cost and easy to manage
- Addresses misinformation, a major social issue

Weaknesses:

- Limited to one platform
- No dedicated mobile application
- Relies heavily on audience engagement

Opportunities:

- High Instagram usage among Pakistani youth
- Increasing demand for digital and media literacy
- Potential collaborations with universities, NGOs, and media outlets
- Can expand into a full digital campaign

Threats:

- Competition with entertainment-based content
- Rapid spread of misinformation
- Limited funding for long-term expansion

CONCLUSION:

The literature consistently supports the notion that misinformation cannot be effectively countered through censorship or punitive measures alone; rather, education and awareness are the most sustainable defenses. Gamified media literacy initiatives have emerged as a creative and evidence-based solution to this problem. The Factly project situates itself within this growing body of global research, offering a context-specific, youth-centered model for Pakistan. By blending Mass Communication principles with interactive digital tools, it has the potential to foster a generation that is not only media-savvy but also socially responsible and critically informed.

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